This spicy, exotically flavored carrot soup makes an elegant starter. Serve it with lime wedges so that guests can adjust the flavor to their liking.

carrot soup with coconut and lemongrass

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 35 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

2 tbsp vegetable oil or sunflower oil
1 onion, chopped
1 lemongrass stalk, trimmed and tough outer layer discarded
2 garlic cloves, chopped
2 tsp finely grated ginger
1 tbsp red Thai curry paste
1lb (450g) carrots, sliced
1 quart (1 liter) hot vegetable stock
3 kaffir lime leaves
1 x 6oz (165ml) can coconut milk
salt and freshly ground black pepper
lime wedges, to serve

1 Heat the oil in a large saucepan, add the onion, and cook for 3–4 minutes or until starting to soften. Meanwhile, finely chop the lemongrass, then add to the pan along with the garlic and ginger, and cook for 2 minutes. Add the curry paste and cook for 1 minute, stirring all the time, then add the carrots and cook for 2 minutes. Pour in the stock, add the lime leaves, and simmer for 20–25 minutes or until the carrots are tender.

2 Remove from the heat and take out and discard the lime leaves. Pour in the coconut milk, then process in a blender or food processor until smooth. The soup shouldn't be too thick—dilute with more stock if it is. Season to taste with salt, then serve with a grinding of black pepper and lime wedges.